

Regular Meeting
December 5, 2016
School Committee Meeting
Council Chambers

The regular meeting of the Medford School Committee was called to order by Mayor Burke in the City Hall Council Chambers at 7:00 p.m. Those present were Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Musatone, Mr. Skerry, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke and Superintendent Belson. Ms. Cugno was absent.

On the motion of Ms. Mustone to suspend the rules to take papers out of order to discuss
Resolution 2:

Vote:

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

Mayor Burke read the resolution as follows:

I respectfully request and recommend that your Honorable Body accept the provisions of G.L.c 71 section 55D. The statute states as follows:

- (a) Upon the issuance of a musical wind instrument to a student who is permitted to use or borrow the instrument while attending any public or commonwealth charter school or prekindergarten to grade 12, inclusive, the school issuing the instrument shall inform the student's parent or guardian that the musical wind instrument has been sanitized and may also be sterilized at the expense of the parent or guardian requesting the sterilization to ensure that all microbial life has been eradicated from the instrument. The parent or guardian may request that the school sterilize the instrument prior to issuance in compliance with regulations promulgated by the department of public health. The parent or guardian who makes the request shall be responsible for the entire cost of the sterilization.
- (b) This section shall take effect in any city, town or g\regional school district upon acceptance by the school committee or, in the case of a commonwealth charter school, upon acceptance by the board of trustees.

Respectfully submitted,

Mayor Stephanie M. Burke

On the motion of Mr. Skerry to move approval

Attorney Rumley commented that the resolution is a matter of notification and information to parents. Ms. DiBenedetto asked what the cost is and how long it lasts. She encourages participation. Attorney Rumley answered saying it is done once per year at an approximate cost of \$125. Superintendent Belson noted that at the present time there are seventy-six wind instruments being rented – sixty-six at the elementary schools and ten at the middle schools. Attorney Rumley stated that the parents make the choice between sanitization and sterilization. Attorney Victor Garo explained the difference between sanitization and sterilization. He also stated that the only way to clean the instruments and be sure that all bacteria is killed is with ethylene oxide. Ms. Van der

Kloot commented that the statute says we should tell parents about the option for sterilization and that is what we are voting on; it is clear cut. Ms. Mustone asked about the process. Attorney Garro said that it is about \$75 and should be done before each new student or once per year. Ms. Van der Kloot would like the school committee to see the flyer that will go to parents. Superintendent Belson said he would like to clarify that when a student uses or borrows an instrument parents must be notified. The information will contain the pros, cons and pricing. It is then up to the parents to make a decision.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot to approve the resolution
Roll Call:

Yea: 6 DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 1 Cugno

On the motion to revert back to the regular order of business.

Vote:

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto that the minutes of November 21, 2016 be approved:

Vote:

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto that the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved:

Voted: That the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 6 DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 1 Cugno

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot that the Payrolls be approved:

Voted: That the Payrolls be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 6 DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 1 Cugno

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot to suspend the rules to take papers out of order to discuss Resolution 1:

Vote:

Yes: 6
No: 0

Absent: 1

Mayor Burke read the resolution:

- Whereas: The strength of our nation is derived from its history of diversity that has enriched our communities with a variety of cultures, faith traditions and viewpoints, and
- Whereas: The City of Medford is a community that welcomes and values the varied racial and ethnic makeup of our residents, and
- Whereas: The City of Medford stands in support of all immigrant groups and newcomers as they pursue the ‘American Dream’, and
- Whereas: The City of Medford will work to model our City as a safe and welcoming place that equally encourages all to seek personal advancement and to reside in peaceful contentment in Medford, and
- Whereas: The City of Medford rejects all words and acts of hate, indifference, and intolerance that undermine our neighborhoods, communities of faith, and our schools, and thwart the promise of equal justice, and
- Whereas: Our nation was founded on the fundamental principle that all persons are entitled to equal protection of law, equal opportunity, and to the enjoyment of civil and human rights;

Now therefore, the City of Medford proudly supports the Medford Conversations Project to promote dialogue and collaboration about Race and Ethnicity in Medford and Beyond.

Discussion:

Mayor Burke introduced Rev. Wendy Miller Olapade, lead pastor of the Sanctuary UCC. Rev. Olapade briefly discussed the mission of the project – to bring people together to have conversations about race and ethnicity in Medford and beyond and to make Medford a better place to be. The first conversation is scheduled for January 2017. Steve Schepp, 86 Hillside Avenue, Medford said it is important that people of different diversity and culture come together. People will get to know each other and who they are. Everyone will talk together. Ms. DiBenedetto commented that our community meets the mission but encourages people to join. She feels that our community already does this. Mayor Burke said this is to provide a unified voice. Superintendent Belson said that we need to reemphasize the importance especially to our students. Adults need to reinforce this topic so that it shows students how important it is to get along. Ms. Van der Kloot stated it is time to reinforce our values.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot seconded by Mr. Skerry to accept the resolution
Roll Call:

Yea: 6 DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 1 Cugno

Update Report on Science Program Initiatives

Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson presented the report due to the illness of Rocco Cieri, Director of Science. Ms. Nelson reported that the science department is very proactive in seeking out opportunities for students to experience real science in a variety of ways. As a result of these efforts we are pleased to report that this year there are a variety of grants and programs that will benefit our students in all grade levels. At the

elementary level the Mystic River Watershed Association was awarded a grant to support river herring migration education and outreach. Medford was one of the communities asked to be part of the grant. At the middle school level three teachers are participating in the implementation of “WATER Science” an Innovative Technology in science project for the topic of environmental science. Students learn about water quality, observe local watershed topic areas using GIS data, participate in a design challenge to clean water and learn about water-related STEM careers. Medford was also asked to partner in another project with the Concord Consortium. The middle school project is titled “Precipitating Change: embedding computational thinking into the middle school science classroom.” The high school project is entitled “Linking complex systems: promoting reasoning within and across interconnected complex system.: Grassroots Wildlife Conservation, Zoo New England and Medford High School teachers applied for a grant and were awarded a small amount to continue the marbled salamander reintroduction program. Two teachers are also part of a vertical teaming project. One grade 6 teacher and one high school teacher. Training will begin in late June. The science department is excited about all the programs and opportunities for our staff and students. We will continue to seek additional opportunities to enrich our science curriculum and provide students with real-world science offerings.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot was pleased to announce that the Medford Educational Foundation has awarded two grants to teachers for science projects. One at the elementary level and one at the high school level. Mr. Skerry commented that it is great to see all the new initiatives in science being pursued. Ms. Mustone asked about the curriculum materials that was discussed in October and where we stand. She expected a meeting to be scheduled by now for early January. Ms. Nelson answered that with the new science frameworks the district has to look at the curriculum and then make adjustments as needed. We need to wait and not jump in. Ms. Mustone commented that Medford is 14% off in science relative to the state.

On the motion to accept the report and place on file.

Vote:

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

Report on Credit Recovery

Deputy Superintendent Beverly Nelson presented the report. She stated that credit recovery for many years has been an option for students who need to make up course credits for a variety of reasons. It is important that these students have the opportunity to obtain these credits so they can graduate from high school on time with their class. Often in order to obtain missed credit students will double up on traditional courses taught by faculty; however this is not always an option especially for students in their last two years of high school. To date, Medford has not had an option for students who need to recover credit other than repeating the regular course during the school year or in summer school. Many of our students have been referred by guidance and high school administrators to outside sources for credit recovery. Over the past few months administrators have been working in developing our own credit recovery option for students. Having our own

option will allow us to better monitor both the curriculum taught as well as the progress students are making.

The following protocol is to be put in place for all juniors and seniors commencing school year 2016-2017

1. All credit recovery courses must be taken through the Medford Public School online offerings.
No outside of district programs will be accepted for credit recovery unless approved by the Director of Guidance
2. Each course will cost \$125.00
3. Students requesting credit recovery must complete the attached Medford Credit Recovery Course Approval Form (attached)
4. Online courses approved for credit recovery must have the endorsement of the Director of Curriculum and Instruction.
5. The Director of Guidance will maintain all records of students enrolled in credit recovery courses for MHS, MVTHS and the Curtis Tufts
6. Student liaisons for credit recovery are Principals or Assistant Principals/Directors as designated by the Principals
7. The Director of Instructional Technology and/or his designee will maintain all records related to the use of the online courses

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot asked if they take the course at home or at school? Ms. Nelson answered either that we can view if student is doing the work. Ms. Van der Kloot asked if this allows for a student who received a “D” to better the grade. Ms. Nelson replied that it has many options and modifications that can be developed as we get further into the program. Ms. Van der Kloot would like the protocol amended to read that “*No outside of district programs will be accepted for credit recovery unless approved by the Director of Guidance.*”

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot to approve as amended

Vote:

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot seconded by Mr. Skerry to accept report and place on file.

Vote:

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

Report on Michigan Model Health Education Program

Assistant Superintendent Diane Caldwell and Rachel Perry, Supervisor of Physical Education presented the report. Ms. Caldwell reported that the Medford Public Schools has adopted the nationally recognized Michigan Model for health curriculum, which is a comprehensive, skills based health education curriculum that is research based and aligned to national standards. The elementary schools are covering the social emotional

units in grades k-5. This includes understanding your feelings, problem solving, decision making, communication skills, conflict resolution and anger management. Adoption of the Michigan Model at the elementary level provides consistency and articulation of the k-12 health curriculum. In addition Medford Police also present the DARE program to all fifth grade students. Rachel Perry shared the history of the Michigan Model implementation at the middle and high school levels and the results of the elementary pre-test score.

Discussion:

Ms. Mustone said that sexting is a concern and asked if there is a policy. Ms. Perry said that this topic is discussed at the middle school and again in high school. Superintendent Belson replied that there is a policy on reasonable use of technology and this topic can be addressed in the curriculum. Ms. Van der Kloot commented that we should think about addressing the issue with students about sexting and how to deal with it. It is a very important conversation to have. Ms. DiBenedetto suggested bringing the curriculum from the high school to the middle school if appropriate. Ms. Van der Kloot said that she is hearing that it is not happening in middle school. Ms. DiBenedetto said that middle school students are talking about this so we need to talk about it too. She suggested discussing the policy at a meeting. Ms. Perry answered that it is discussed as part of the middle school curriculum.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto seconded by Ms. Mustone to have a protocol in place if teachers hear something outside and asked the Superintendent to write a draft policy.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot seconded by Ms. Mustone the report was accepted and placed on file.

Vote:

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

Report on Scheduling of Professional Development Day

The first of the two mandated days of professional development for teachers and paraprofessionals took place on Tuesday November 8th. Similar to last year we did not schedule the second day until we had an idea of the timing of the state assessments and other needs of the district related to professional development for staff. At this time we are scheduling the second full mandated day of professional development for teachers and paraprofessionals to take place on Monday, March 13, 2017. The school calendar will be edited to reflect this date and principals will be asked to inform parents and staff. We want to prepare parents/guardians to make plans as students will not be attending school that day.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot the report was accepted and placed on file.

Vote:

Yes: 6
No: 0
Absent: 1

Report on Proposed Change to Educator Evaluation Regulations

Superintendent Belson reported that on Tuesday, November 29th the Board of Elementary and Secondary Education discussed a proposed change to the DESE regulations regarding the use of “student learning impact ratings” as an integral part of education evaluations. Commissioner Mitchell Chester introduced the proposed changes because of the feedback he has received from the field that the existing regulations were an unworkable distraction and not as beneficial as originally planned. The current regulations were adapted in 2011 and set up a system where educators would receive two separate ratings. The first would focus on overall performance based upon a four category rubric and the second would be based upon student learning impact which included state assessment scores. Instead the Commissioner recommended that “student learning impact: be included in Standard 2 as a portion of that rubric rather than as a discrete stand-alone rating. Teacher unions are against both the current and proposed regulations regarding the use of student test scores.

MASC, Superintendents and Principals Associations support the changes with the understanding that the metrics to be used are flexible based upon teacher assignments. All changes would have to be bargained with the unions. The Board moved the process for possible change forward by releasing the proposed amendments for public comment. Since this topic will be an important element of public policy and will undoubtedly affect future negotiations, it is important that we stay informed on the issue and be prepared to devise a local plan to implement whatever emerges from this process.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot the report was accepted and placed on file.

Vote:

Yes: 6

No: 0

Absent: 1

Report on School Nutrition Equipment Grant

Director of Finance and Administration Kirsteen Patterson presented the report. She stated that the Medford Public Schools has been awarded \$20,812 under the USDA School Nutrition Equipment Grant. Massachusetts was allocated \$427,282 from USDA and received \$1,217,488 in requests from districts across the Commonwealth. The grant application was prepared by our food service department under the direction of Juile Bradley. The grant will fund the following:

McGlynn Middle School	
Heated Hold Oven	\$10,406
Columbus Elementary School	
Heated Hold Oven	\$10,406

Funding priority was given to schools with at least 50% of students eligible for free and reduced priced meals. These items will help increase the efficiency of food preparation at the respective schools.

Discussion:

Ms. Mustone asked if those are the only pieces of equipment that could be purchased. Ms. Patterson answered yes because of the specifications of the grant. Ms. DiBenedetto commented that she would like the prices of school lunches to be looked at and if prices have to rise to please

give everyone plenty of notice. It is a hardship for many. Superintendent Belson said that it is uncertain of the prices going forward but they try very hard not to raise them.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto to accept the grant.

Roll Call:

Yea: 6 DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 1 Cugno

Old Business

Please find attached the draft letter to our state legislative delegation regarding the implementation of the recently enacted law on the use of “recreational marijuana.” The MASS advisory points out several salient facts and applications of similar laws throughout the U.S. Please read it so that you will have a more complete picture of the challenges that will be faced by school systems and the general public with this law pending regulations. With the Committee’s approval this advisory will be added to our correspondence to the state legislative delegation. It must be noted that the Federal law and regulations are unchanged by legalization at the state level. This includes the Controlled Substance Act and the Drug-Free Schools and Communities Act. Neither the state’s recreational or medical marijuana laws require school districts to permit or accommodate marijuana use on school grounds. However, it is too new to be completely definitive until the law and regulations evolve. The law is also unsettled as to the use of medical marijuana off school grounds. Given the age requirements of the law it may pose a significant question regarding employees. There is a lot to be worked out regarding marijuana laws as they interact with school law and federal requirements.

To: Senator Jehlen
Representatives Donato, Garballey and Barber

From: Medford School Committee

Date: November 30, 2016

Since the voters legalized recreational marijuana without sufficient regulatory provisions in place, the new law in its current form has the potential to create significant safety hazards.

Governor Baker, Senate President Rosenberg and House Speaker DeLeo have all agreed that the law generated through initiative petition needs to be “fixed.” They all believe that there is a need to make changes necessary to protect public health and safety. We ask that the actions be taken as soon as possible to improve the control of recreational marijuana use and distribution. There are many challenges associated with the specifics of the law.

Considering the recent emphasis that has been placed on the use and abuse of opioids, the introduction of recreational marijuana into the Commonwealth without sufficient controls is troubling. Although the law sets the age at twenty-one, it is unrealistic to believe that

with significantly increased availability and the advent of “homegrown” production that younger, school age persons will not gain substantial access.

The Medford School Committees and School Administration urge the legislature and Governor to take the necessary actions to prevent the misuse of this substance. We recommend the following for your consideration:

1. Provide for a local “opt in” provision. Currently the law would require communities to hold a referendum to “opt out.” The “opt in” provision would mirror the Colorado law where 70% of the communities banned marijuana outlets locally. It is one thing to agree that legalization is acceptable and another to support it in your own community.
2. Substantially increase the tax rate on marijuana. There will be a significant cost for regulating this new law. The revenue seems enticing but the expenses may wipe it away.
3. Eliminate the “Home Grown Plant” provision. This provision will not be adequately enforced/taxed. Also the potential for contaminated product is dramatically increased. It also makes it more possible for under age persons to access the product.
4. Strengthen the Control Commission to better understand the impact and to effectively regulate the industry. The commission should have a staff that collects data to inform future modifications that may be necessary to protect public safety.

The initiative petition process can be a valuable part of our democratic system. However, it is a blunt instrument that needs to be refined. The will of the people can be respected, but it deserves the review of our lawmakers before it unleashes harmful, random outcomes. This is especially true when we consider our continuing struggle with addiction prevention and public safety.

Please find attached an advisory from Long and DiPietro, LLP who are the legal counsel for the Massachusetts Association of School Superintendents. This advisory will provide you with additional information regarding the complexity of implementing this law.

Thank you for your consideration of our concerns.

On behalf of the Medford School Committee,

Roy E. Belson
Superintendent

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot to accept the draft and send the letter

Yea: 6 DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 1 Cugno

On the motion of Ms. Vander Kloot seconded by Mr. Skerry the meeting was adjourned at 8:47 p.m.

Roll Call:

Yea: 6 DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0

Absent: 1 Cugno

Respectfully submitted:

Robert E. Skerry Jr.
Secretary